

The restoration of the Judæan church as proposed by the Babylonian Diaspora and effectively undertaken by Ezra and Nehemia was ecclesiastical; it was a proposition not of the family of David, nor of the highpriests, for these were likely to be as secular-minded as royalty, but of the doctors of the Tora, whose schools flourished in the new home and produced as their *pièce de résistance* the Law, or at least its first draft in the Priest Code. We can imagine the opposition to this policy produced in the minds of the people in Judæa, the Am-ha-areç or Boors, as they were contemptuously called by the Babylonian exiles.⁴⁴ The majority in any church is worldly-minded, does not easily or for long acquiesce in Puritanism. But now the social liberties of the Palestinians were to be restricted, their franchise in the community reduced to little or nothing. Rebellion to the Babylonian policy, feud between the elements of the community, excommunication of the dissatisfied, — these were the results of the second restoration.

How far "the Law of the Lord which was in the hand of Ezra the scribe" met with success we cannot judge, but that ecclesiastic evidently failed in the matter nearest to his heart. He attacked with burning zeal the practice of intermarriage with the peoples of the lands, requiring that all such unions should be ruthlessly broken. The people seem to have sullenly allowed the appointment of a commission to settle the grievous matter. And then the history abruptly concludes (*Ezra*, 9-10). As Nehemia had to solve the problem afresh, we must conclude that Ezra failed. The ties of humanity outwitted the priest.

Ezra's successor, the governor Nehemia (445-433), was a far more strenuous yet withal more politic ruler. Backed

⁴⁴ The term, which was once simply a social one, "the country-people," may have largely obtained its sinister meaning through confusion with the other, "the peoples of the lands," designating the Gentile colonists; the various texts and versions of Ezra-Nehemia evince this confusion in the varying use of the singular and plural.